

A New Grammar of Consumption

Consumption, for Gen Z, is not a response to a need but to constant exposure



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LIVING INSIDE A digital world changes everything. Unlike previous generations for whom technology was a facility, something one used for a reason while remaining outside, Gen Z is the first generation that lives inside it. No wonder physical reality is termed ‘off-line’, acknowledging that the default is ‘on-line’.

The other fundamental shift is in the fact that this generation experiences itself as individuals in a way that is unprecedented. The very act of living inside their phones, through which they share a unique one-on-one relationship with the outside world, and one where every whim of theirs is read as a command, gives them a feeling of specialness that works at a visceral level. It also makes consumption a part of their search for identity.

The need to constantly put oneself on public display through social media means that this identity must be performed minute by minute. Consumption becomes a costume drama of their beta selves, perpetually seeking to find a version of themselves that is more appropriate in a changing context.

Which is why the attempt to find coherence in their actions is often frustrating. These are not contradictions—imply reactions to a world of constant stimulation where one flits through several versions of one-

self in a single day. The belief, for instance, that Gen Z is drawn to ideas of sustainability might get rudely challenged when the same person opts for a fast fashion product in the next breath.

Gen Z also sits at a peculiar junction, sandwiched between stability and volatility. This is a generation that has seen all concepts change—the meaning of work has transformed, benchmarks of success have gone haywire with 19-year-old billionaires, relationships have become complicated, choices have multiplied, and the pressure to constantly define oneself is relentless.

This means that consumption becomes significant even at the granular level. And indulgence is sought on a daily basis, beginning with the smallest items. A cup of artisanal coffee, a health bar, a new skincare regimen, a new D@C brand curated by an influencer—all of these become small highlights in a day. They help pepper the day with meaning much like social media, giving small dopamine hits that keep one going. They are also vital instruments in the never-ending projecting of constructing and broadcasting one’s ever-evolving identity.

Experimentation becomes much easier when one is constantly in hunting mode. The cost of failure is low, and the opportunity to try anything once is all around. A 19-year-old in Indore can develop a “Tokyo mini-